Fentanyl Facts

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For Everyone

KEY POINTS

- Fentanyl is a synthetic opioid that is up to 50 times stronger than heroin and 100 times stronger than morphine.
- It is a major contributor to fatal and nonfatal overdoses in the U.S.



The facts about fentanyl

There are two types of fentanyl: **pharmaceutical fentanyl** and **illegally made fentanyl**. Both are considered synthetic opioids (made in a laboratory). Pharmaceutical fentanyl is prescribed by doctors to treat severe pain, especially after surgery and for advanced-stage cancer.

However, most recent cases of fentanyl-related overdose are linked to illegally made fentanyl, which is distributed through illegal drug markets for its heroin-like effect. [1] It is often added to other drugs because of its extreme potency, which makes drugs cheaper, more powerful, more addictive, and more dangerous.

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Illegally made fentanyl

Illegally made fentanyl (IMF) is available on the drug market in different forms, including liquid and powder. [2]

Powdered fentanyl looks just like many other drugs. It is commonly mixed with drugs like heroin, cocaine, and methamphetamine and made into pills that are made to resemble other prescription opioids. Drugs mixed with fentanyl are extremely dangerous, and many people may be unaware that their drugs contain it.

In its liquid form, IMF can be found in nasal sprays, eye drops, and dropped onto paper or small candies.

Fentanyl and overdose

Synthetic opioids like fentanyl contribute to nearly 70% of overdose deaths. [3] Even in small doses, it can be deadly. [4] [5] [6] Over the last few years, nonfatal and fatal overdoses involving fentanyl have continued to rise. [4] [5] [7]

Drugs may contain deadly levels of fentanyl, and you wouldn't be able to see it, taste it, or smell it. It is nearly impossible to tell if drugs have been mixed with fentanyl unless you test your drugs with fentanyl test strips.

Test strips to detect fentanyl are inexpensive and typically give results within 5 minutes, which can be the difference between life or death. Even if the test is negative, take caution as test strips might not detect more potent fentanyl-like drugs, like carfentanil. [6]

Fentanyl mixed with Xylazine is an emerging threat

Xylazine is a non-opioid sedative that is increasingly being found in the US illegal drug supply and linked to overdose deaths. Xylazine can be life-threatening and is especially dangerous when combined with opioids like fentanyl.

What You Should Know About Xylazine

Resources

- What to do if you think someone is overdosing
- CDC Podcast – The Dangers of Fentanyl [MP3 – 12 MB] MP3
- The Facts About Fentanyl [PDF – 422 KB] PDF
- Explore overdose prevention materials on CDC's Overdose Resource Exchange.

SOURCES AND PAGE INFO

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